

Beijing 2008

GUEST COLUMN



SHANE GOULD

The wait for eight

An Olympic legend on an old, formidable record, new superfast swimsuits and what really makes for greatness in the sporting world's big festival

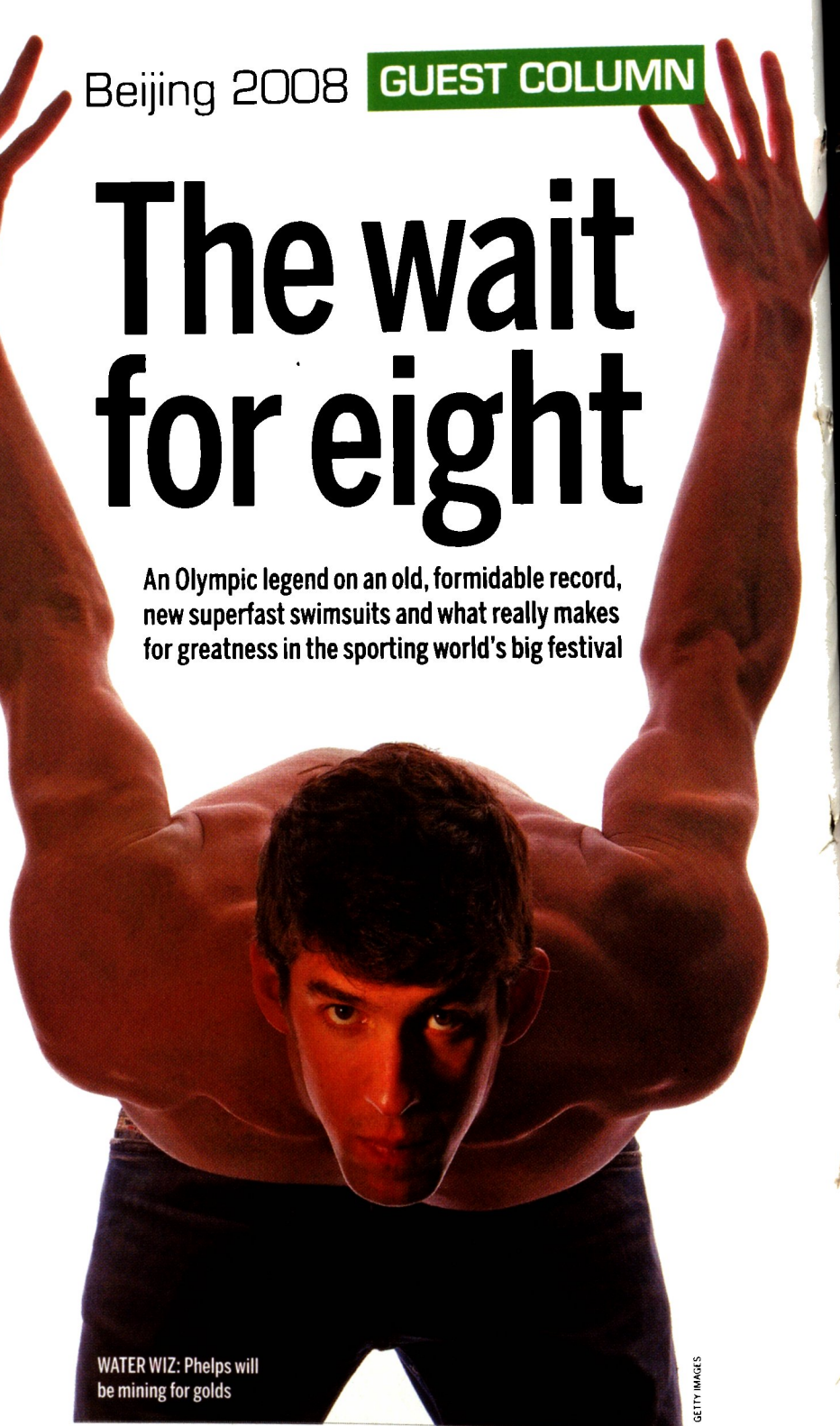
The most prestigious record in Olympic history is up for a mighty challenge in the first week of the Beijing Olympic Games 2008.

The record has stood since 1972 when Mark Spitz won seven swimming gold medals to the astonishment of the sports world. It is still the most golds ever won by an athlete at a single Games. At the 1972 Olympics, I was a youthfully-confident and focussed 15-year-old, having my own 'party' in the pool. I raced five individual events and two relays, winning medals in all the individual events: three golds, all in world record time, one silver, and a bronze.

So the dominant story of the first week of the Munich Games was around 'the Gouldfish' from Australia and the American Spitz. We were photographed and interviewed together for magazines, newspapers and TV around the world. This was the only time we met and talked, as both our swimming schedules were very full and engaging.

I was impressed by Spitz's handsome features, and his 'signature' moustache, but wasn't overawed by his success. We were colleagues, performing on a world stage, swimming was our act. He was friendly and easy to talk to and swam fast and powerfully, that's what I remember of him in the water.

Now, 36 years later, the challenger to Mark Spitz's record is his remarkably-talented countryman Michael Phelps. In Athens 2004, Phelps won eight medals, six gold, and two bronze. Now in Beijing, with many thousands of kilometres and hours more training and racing under his belt, Phelps is fit, faster and more competitive. He has



WATER WIZ: Phelps will be mining for golds

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THE NEW RECORD-BREAKING SWIMSUITS SIGNAL A TECHNOLOGICAL CHANGE NEVER SEEN BEFORE.

qualified to swim all of the same five individual events in which he won medals in Athens. It is highly likely that he will also swim in the three relays again.

He goes in to the five individual events ranked as the fastest swimmer

this year and world record holder in four of them. In the 100m butterfly, Ian Crocker, his US team-mate, is world record holder; he may be the one to upset the Phelps festival, only just slightly slower than him in the US